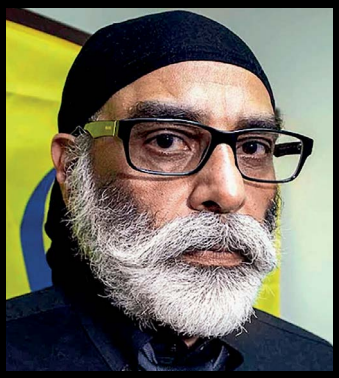
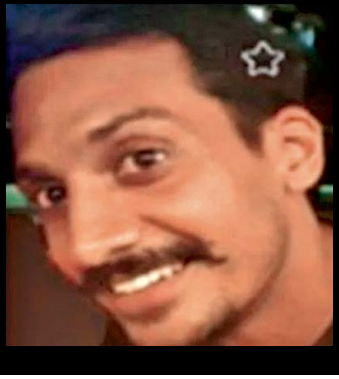
suit of this mission, he is said to have recruited Gupta, who apparently listed "involvement in international narcotics and weapons trafficking" in his resume to Yadav, to find someone to carry out the plot in return for getting a case against him in India dismissed. It is at this point that the amateurishness of the Indian spies seems to have kicked in. Gupta, the indictment says, contacted an individual whom he believed was a criminal associate, but who was actually 'CS', a "confidential source working with US law enforcement", the Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA) to be precise. This person's job was to find a hitman for the Indian duo, and he obliged, giving them 'UC', who was, in fact, another undercover DEA officer. The payment was agreed upon too—$100,000—and advance payment of $15,000 made around June 9, 2023, via a source in Manhattan, New York, a still image of which is carried in the indictment.

Subsequently, Yadav via Gupta also provided UC with details of Pannun's address, phone numbers and daily routine. Yadav also wanted regular updates on the plot's progress, and Gupta complied, forwarding him surveillance photographs of Pannun, supplied by UC. Gupta also regularly communicated to UC the urgency to finish the task, except around the time Prime Minister Narendra Modi was to visit the US on June 21, 2023. But three days before the scheduled trip, Nijjar was murdered outside a Sikh temple in British Columbia, Canada. Yadav is alleged to have sent Gupta a video clip of Nijjar's slumped body in his car. Gupta, in turn, told UC that Nijjar, too, was a target, that they had many targets and directed CS to "find the opportunity" to kill Pannun and to "do it quickly". "Before the 29th of June, we have to finish four jobs," Gupta is said to have told CS. The reference is to Pannun and "three in Canada", says the US indictment. All that came a cropper on June 30, 2023, when



INTELLIGENCE EXPERTS ARE CRITICAL OF THE AMATEURISHNESS OF THE ENTIRE AFFAIR. THAT RAW SHOULD EMPLOY AN EX-CRPF OFFICER (YADAV, BELOW) TO PLOT PANNUN'S (TOP) KILLING AND LEAVE BEHIND A WHOLE COMMUNICATION TRAIL



Gupta was arrested in Prague at the US's request in connection with the Pannun plot and extradited to the US, where he now faces trial.

Operation Mess-Up

The Indian ministry of external affairs was quick to state that Yadav was no longer in their employ. Yet, two months after Gupta's indictment became public, Yadav was made senior field officer at RAW's sister agency, the Aviation Research Centre, which specialises in image intelligence. In December 2023, he was arrested by the special cell of the Delhi Police in a case of kidnapping and extortion but released on bail in April this year. His current whereabouts remain unknown.

Although the hand of the Indian government has yet to be proved, the entire saga has triggered questions about potential overreach by the Indian intelligence establishment and if involved, how it botched up the operation. There is consternation within the intelligence community itself—about untrained personnel being involved in sensitive operations, basic spycraft protocols being violated, whether in choice of intermediaries or of hitmen. An intelligence officer criticises the very selection of Yadav for such a mission. A CRPF officer, Yadav was on deputation to RAW for nine years before securing a permanent appointment. The CRPF, he says, lacks intelligence cadre experienced in covert foreign operations. "There's always pressure to complete a mission quickly and, in their rush to impress superiors, mistakes are made," adds another official.

Another top intelligence officer rues the complete lack of HUMINT, or human intelligence, and the over-reliance on digital communication. As the indictment shows, most of Yadav's and Gupta's conversations took place on phone and encrypted applications. Yadav, in fact, reached out to Gupta on an encrypted app, introducing himself as Vikas and asking him to save his number under Aman. Information about a "target in New York" and another in "California" followed soon from the same number, which had an Indian country code and was registered to an email account that accessed the internet near New Delhi. Over the next few weeks, the indictment says, Gupta communicated with CS and UC over phone, via video and text messages, discussing, among other things, the logistics and price of the murder.

One of the key conversations, the